# Apple Business: What SMBs Need to Know

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## A Single Platform for Everything Apple at Work

On April 14, 2026, Apple is consolidating Apple Business Manager, Apple Business Essentials, and Apple Business Connect into one unified platform: Apple Business. For small and medium-sized businesses already invested in the Apple ecosystem, this is a significant shift that simplifies management, deployment, and brand presence — all from a single console.

If your organization uses any of Apple's business services today, migration is not optional. The legacy services will be discontinued on April 14. Here is what you need to know.

## What You Get for Free

The base Apple Business platform is available at no cost and includes a surprisingly capable set of tools.

### Built-In MDM and Blueprints

Apple Business includes native mobile device management (MDM) with Blueprints, a zero-touch deployment system that lets you preconfigure devices before they even reach your employees. Define security policies, install apps, configure Wi-Fi and VPN settings, and assign devices to teams — all without touching each device individually.

For SMBs that previously relied on third-party MDM solutions or manual setup, this alone can save hours per device.

### Managed Apple Accounts

Every employee gets a Managed Apple Account tied to your organization. These accounts are separate from personal Apple IDs, giving your business control over corporate data while respecting employee privacy. Managed accounts integrate with identity providers via federated authentication, so you can connect them to your existing SSO infrastructure.

### Business Email, Calendar, and Directory

Apple Business provides business email, shared calendars, and a company directory hosted on your custom domain. This is a meaningful alternative to third-party productivity suites for teams that want to stay fully within the Apple ecosystem.

> **ℹ Note**
>
> Important: Business email and calendar features require devices running iOS 26, iPadOS 26, or macOS 26, which ship later in 2026. Plan your device upgrade timeline accordingly.

## Brand Management Across Apple Services

Apple Business consolidates brand presence management that was previously scattered across Apple Business Connect and other tools.

### Apple Maps, Wallet, and Mail

From the Apple Business console, you can manage your business listings on Apple Maps, create branded passes for Apple Wallet (loyalty cards, event tickets, boarding passes), and configure your verified brand identity in Apple Mail. For customer-facing businesses, this is a straightforward way to maintain a consistent brand across every Apple touchpoint.

### Tap to Pay on iPhone

Tap to Pay on iPhone is integrated directly into Apple Business, allowing you to accept contactless payments without additional hardware. For retail, service, and field businesses, this eliminates the need for separate payment terminal agreements and hardware.

### Ads on Apple Maps

Starting in summer 2026, businesses in the United States and Canada will be able to purchase advertising placements on Apple Maps. Details on pricing and targeting are still emerging, but this represents a new local discovery channel worth watching.

## Optional Paid Add-Ons

While the core platform is free, Apple offers two paid tiers for additional services.

### iCloud Storage for Business

Additional iCloud storage for Managed Apple Accounts starts at $0.99 per user per month. This covers cloud storage for documents, backups, and collaboration features tied to the business account. Pricing scales with storage tiers, similar to consumer iCloud+ plans.

### AppleCare+ for Business

Device protection through AppleCare+ for Business ranges from $6.99 to $13.99 per device per month, depending on the device type. This covers accidental damage, battery replacement, and priority support. For organizations with significant hardware investments, the per-device monthly model can be more predictable than handling repairs ad hoc.

## Migration Path from Legacy Services

If your organization currently uses Apple Business Manager, Apple Business Essentials, or Apple Business Connect, you will need to migrate before April 14, 2026. Apple has published migration guides for each service, and in most cases the transition involves signing into Apple Business with your existing credentials and following the guided setup.

Key migration considerations:

1. Apple Business Manager users: Device enrollments and app assignments carry over, but review your MDM configurations against the new Blueprints system
2. Apple Business Essentials users: Your existing device management policies will be migrated, but verify that all settings transferred correctly
3. Apple Business Connect users: Brand information and location data should migrate automatically, but audit your listings after the transition
4. Third-party MDM: If you use a third-party MDM alongside Apple's tools, confirm compatibility with the new Apple Business APIs

## How chen.ist Can Help

At chen.ist, we have been working with Apple Business since the early access programme and are prepared to help SMBs navigate this transition. Our services include:

- Migration planning from legacy Apple services to Apple Business
- Blueprint configuration for zero-touch device deployment
- Identity integration connecting Managed Apple Accounts with your existing SSO provider
- Brand setup across Apple Maps, Wallet, and Mail
- Ongoing management and support for your Apple Business environment

Whether you are starting fresh or migrating from an existing setup, we can help you get the most out of the platform from day one.

## Ready to set up Apple Business?

Book a free consultation to discuss your migration plan and get started before the April 14 deadline.

Book a Consultation